

Sentences

THERE ARE MANY DIFFERENT TYPES OF SENTENCES, VARYING IN COMPLEXITY.

A sentence is a unit of written language that contains a subject and a verb and makes complete sense on its own. It must begin with a capital letter and end with a period, exclamation point, or question mark.

SEE ALSO

◀ 38–39	Verbs
◀ 54–55	Voices and moods
◀ 64–65	Phrases
◀ 66–67	Clauses
Compound sentences	70–71 ▶
Complex sentences	72–73 ▶
Periods and ellipses	94–95 ▶
Question marks	110–111 ▶
Exclamation points	112–113 ▶

Simple sentences

A simple sentence is the same as a main clause. It must have a subject and one main verb, and it must express a single idea. The subject is the person or thing that does the action (the verb), but one subject can be made up of more than one person or thing. Most simple sentences also include an object, which is the person or thing receiving the action.

capital letter
The chef cooked.
 subject verb
 A period ends the sentence.

Descriptive words and phrases can be added to give more information, but if there is still only one verb, it remains a simple sentence.

The chef and his friends ate the delicious meal.
 The subject can represent more than one person or thing. object

Statements

A statement is a sentence that conveys a fact or piece of information. The subject always comes before the verb. Most simple sentences are statements, and statements end with a period.

The pie had exploded.

This is a statement because it states a fact and ends with a period.

Questions

A question is a sentence that asks for information and ends with a question mark. Unlike a statement, the subject is placed after the verb. Only auxiliary verbs can change places with their subjects, so a question must include an auxiliary verb like *be*, *do*, or *can*. Many questions also start with question words such as *why*, *when*, *where*, and *how*.

question word
 subject main verb
Why did the pie explode?
 auxiliary verb

This is a question because it asks for information and ends with a question mark.



- **Shorter sentences** tend to be **more effective** at getting a message across.
- It's important to **vary the sentence construction** in a piece of writing, so that it does not become monotonous.
- **Simple sentences** can be used to **create tension** in a story.